Literature: Drama

H 1780

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A. Recent revisions

2026-01: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.

B. General rule

For collections of plays, assign as many headings as necessary to bring out both the form and the topic(s), as outlined in sections C and D, below. For single plays, assign headings as required to bring out topic(s), but assign form headings only as noted in section E, below.

Assign topical and form headings, especially to single plays or to collections by one author, only as they come readily to mind after a superficial review of the work being cataloged.

LC practice: As stated in H 1075, LC catalogers will no longer use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from Library of Congress Genre/Form Terms (LCGFT), e.g. ***Drama***, ***One-act plays***, etc. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign Library of Congress Demographic Group Terms (LCDGT) to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children***.

C. Designating the form of collections

C.1. General rule

Bring out the form of a collection by assigning headings of the type ***American drama--20th century***; ***One-act plays***; ***Television plays***; etc., as in the first heading in the following example.

Example:

```
Title: Eight plays for hand puppets about George Washington.
   650 #0 $a Puppet plays, American.
   600 10 $a Washington, George, $d 1732-1799 $v Drama.
```

LC practice:

```
   650 #0 $a Puppet plays, American.
   600 10 $a Washington, George, $d 1732-1799.
   655 #7 $a Puppet plays. $2 lcgft
```

Certain phrase headings combine both form and topical aspects into one heading, for example, ***Detective and mystery plays***; ***Christmas plays***; ***Ghost plays***; etc. These headings are used to designate both the form and the topic of collections, and no additional heading is usually required.

Do not use a phrase heading of this type if a more specific ***[topic]--Drama*** heading can be formulated to designate the topic of the collection. Instead, assign the more specific heading in conjunction with a broader, non-topical, form heading.

LC practice: Do not use the form subdivision ***--Drama***. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Drama*** or ***One-act plays***.

For example, assign the following headings to a collection of American plays about the Christian Trinity:

Example:

```
650 #0 $a American drama.
650 #0 $a Trinity $v Drama.

[not 650 #0 $a Christian drama, American.]

[not 650 #0 $a Christian drama, American.
     650 #0 $a Trinity $v Drama.]
```

LC practice:

```
650 #0 $a American drama.
650 #0 $a Trinity.
655 #7 $a Religious drama. $2 lcgft
```

C.2. Collections of plays by one author

As a general rule, assign form headings

a. if the form heading includes a topical aspect, for example, ***Detective and mystery plays, American***, or
b. if the plays are of a highly specific form and the form is an essential point of the collection, for example, ***Carnival plays***; ***College and school drama, Japanese***; etc.

Do not assign nonspecific form headings or standard dramatic genre headings to collections of plays by one author, for example, ***English drama***, ***English drama (Comedy)***; ***Comedy***; ***Farces***; ***Melodrama***; ***One act plays***; ***Tragedy***; ***Tragicomedy***.

Do not attempt to assign a form heading to a collection of plays by one author if the form is not stated on the title page or in another prominent location.

C.3. Collections of children's plays

Assign the heading ***Children's plays*** or ***Children's plays, American, [English, etc.]*** to collections of children's plays, whether by one author or several authors, in addition to the other required form and topical headings.

Example:

```
Title: Igniting wonder : plays for preschoolers.
   650 #0 $a Children’s plays, American.
```

LC practice:

```
650 #0 $a Children’s plays, American.
655 #7 $a Drama. $2 lcgft
```

```
385 ## $a Children $2 lcdgt
```

D. Designating the topics of collections by one or several authors

Bring out identifiable topics, using one of the following types of headings listed in sections D.1-D.2, below.

Do not attempt to discern topics which have not been made explicit by the playwright or publisher, or which could be interpreted as representing value judgments.

D.1. [topic]--Drama or [topic]--Juvenile drama

Use headings of this type as the standard means of designating topics in drama, for example, ***Alcoholism--Drama***; ***Lincoln, Abraham, 1809-1865--Drama***; ***Holmes, Sherlock--Drama***; ***Brontë family--Drama***.

LC practice: Do not use a form subdivision of the type ***--Drama*** or ***--Juvenile drama*.** Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Drama***, ***One-act plays***, etc. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign LCDGT to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children***, ***Teenagers***, etc.

Example:

```
Title: Dramaturgas chilenas : plays by Chilean female writers in the early 21st century.
650 #0 $a Chilean drama $x Women authors $v Translations into English.
650 #0 $a Chilean drama $y 21st century $v Translations into English.
651 #0 $a Chile $v Drama.
```

LC practice:

```
650 #0 $a Chilean drama $x Women authors.
650 #0 $a Chilean drama $y 21st century.
651 #0 $a Chile.
655 #7 $a Drama. $2 lcgft
385 ## $a English speakers $2 lcdgt
```

Example:

```
Title: Plays for the plague year.
650 #0 $a COVID-19 Pandemic, 2020-2023 $z United States $v Drama.
650 #0 $a One-act plays, American.
651 #0 $a United States $x Social conditions $y 2020- $v Drama.
```

LC practice:

650 #0 $a COVID-19 Pandemic, 2020-2023 $z United States.

650 #0 $a One-act plays, American.

651 #0 $a United States $x Social conditions $y 2020-

655 #7 $a One-act plays. $2 lcgft

D.2. Phrase headings with topical aspects

If a phrase heading has both form and topical aspects, assign only the one heading to designate both form and topic, as described in section C.1, above. ***Historical drama*** and ***Political plays*** are examples of such headings.

Example:

Title: The mousetrap and other plays.

650 #0 $a Detective and mystery plays, English.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Detective and mystery plays, English.

655 #7 $a Detective and mystery plays. $2 lcgft

Example:

Title: Wisconsin history on stage : scripts for grades 4 through 8.

650 #0 $a Historical drama, American.

650 #0 $a Children's plays, American.

651 #0 $a Wisconsin $x History $v Juvenile drama.

LC practice:

650 #0 $a Historical drama, American.

650 #0 $a Children's plays, American.

651 #0 $a Wisconsin $x History.

655 #7 $a Historical drama. $2 lcgft

385 ## $a Children $2 lcdgt

385 ## $a Teenagers $2 lcdgt

E. Individual plays

Bring out the topic of an individual play by assigning headings of the type described in section D, above. Assign a form heading only if it includes a topical aspect, or if the play is of a highly specific form, for example, ***Detective and mystery plays, American***; ***Carnival plays***; etc.

Assign the heading ***Children's plays, American [English, etc.]*** to individual children's plays in addition to the required topical heading(s).

Do not assign topical headings to single plays which deal with vague and general topics, such as fate, mankind, belief, malaise, etc.

LC practice: Do not use a form subdivision of the type ***--Drama*** or ***--Juvenile drama*.** Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from LCGFT, e.g. ***Drama***, ***One-act plays***, etc. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign LCDGT to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***Children***, ***Teenagers***, etc.

Example:

```
Title: Becky Nurse of Salem : a contemporary comedy about a historical
tragedy.
   650 #0 $a Tour guides (Persons) $v Drama.
   650 #0 $a Witches $v Drama.
   650 #0 $a American drama (Comedy)
```

LC practice:

```
   650 #0 $a Tour guides (Persons)
   650 #0 $a Witches.
   650 #0 $a American drama (Comedy)
   655 #7 $a Comedy plays. $2 lcgft
```

F. History and criticism

F.1. General rule

For works about particular themes in drama, assign as many headings as necessary to bring out the form (with subdivision ***--History and criticism***) and the topics (normally using headings of the type ***[topic] in literature***).

Examples:

```
   650 #0 $a American drama $y 20th century $x History and criticism.
   650 #0 $a Mental illness in literature.
```

If a heading has both form and topical aspects, assign only the single heading with the subdivision ***--History and criticism***, for example, ***Religious drama--History and criticism***.

F.2. Plays about individual persons or families

For criticism of drama about particular individuals or families, including dynasties and royal houses, assign the name of the person or family with the free-floating subdivision ***--In literature*.**

Examples:

```
600 10 $a Mozart, Wolfgang Amadeus, $d 1756-1791 $x In literature.
600 30 $a Roosevelt family $x In literature.
```

F.3. Plays about individual corporate bodies, places, and sacred works

For criticism of plays about particular corporate bodies, places, or sacred works, assign the name of the entity with the free-floating subdivision ***--In literature*.**

Examples:

```
610 10 $a United States. $b Congress $x In literature.
651 #0 $a Provence (France) $x In literature.
630 00 $a Bible $x In literature.
```

F.4. Plays about wars and similar events

For works about the drama of a specific war, revolution, uprising, etc., assign ***[name of event]--Literature and the war, [revolution, uprising, etc.]*** as a topical heading (cf. H 1200).

Examples:

```
651 #0 $a Great Britain $x History $y Civil War, 1642-1649 $x Literature and
       the war.
650 #0 $a Vietnam War, 1961-1975 $x Literature and the war.
```

F.5. Single plays

For works about a single play with a special theme, assign a heading for the play as well as a heading for the theme.

Example:

```
600 10 $a Heller, Joseph. $t Catch 22, a dramatization.
650 #0 $a World War, 1939-1945 $x Literature and the war.
```

Revision history

2026-01: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.